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Camera Shootout of the Advanced Kind

We compare the popular enthusiast cameras out there to crown the best

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With the point-and-shoot camera market hitting somewhat of a wall in terms of growth, the camera makers figured it was time for the next stage of evolution – advanced point and shoot.

Given the changing trends, manufacturers have started taking the features that make DSLRs so great and packing them into smaller point-n-shoot cameras. In the last two years, we've seen cameras with really fast apertures of f/1.4, we're seeing bigger sensors getting packed into the little cameras not to mention those really convenient dials and controls that are also starting to slowly creep into these little shooters. Normally, if

you want fast apertures of f/1.4, you're going to have to shell out a lot more for the lens than you would for an advanced point and shoot. While the manufacturers are in a giving mood, they're not willing to let the consumer have it all. If you're hoping for a point and shoot with a really fast f/1.4-2.3 lens to also have a large sensor with an excellent 24mm (or wider) to 200mm (or longer) focal length, we recommend you go back to sleep and continue dreaming. There seems to be an underlying trend of crippling even these advanced cameras.

Advanced point and shoot

This is a category we are quite excited about as it is a sign that there truly is a future for the little cameras that fit into our pockets. It is a sign that we may

not have to lug our DSLR kits around just because we want to be sure of not missing that critical shot.

Features and design

Given that the advanced point and shoot segment is still in its infancy, we're not surprised that the feature set is still very fragmented. While one camera might play host to a large sensor, the optics on it might fall short with a relatively slow lens. On the other hand a camera blessed with a fast aperture might falter due to its small 1/1.7-inch sensor, at least when it comes to high ISO performance. Case in point being the Sony RX100 and the Panasonic LX7. While the RX100 has a large 1-inch sensor, its lens has a really slow f/4.9 maximum aperture at the telephoto end. The LX7 on the other

hand, boasts an aperture range of f/1.4-2.3, the fastest in a point and shoot, but the camera gets crippled due to a small sensor. The Canon PowerShot G1x is the powerhouse here, with its huge 1.5-inch APS-C sensor, the first of its kind in a point and shoot camera, but with that huge a sensor comes a major drawback. The minute you lay your hands on a G1X, you'd feel like you'd rather be holding a small DSLR. Not only is the camera huge and bulky, but it also has a relatively slow f/2.8-5.8 lens. The G1x also weighs in at 534 grams, which is not really light so far as point and shoots go. All cameras in our comparison had a pop-up flash, with all the advance cameras also sporting a hot-shoe to attach external speedlights. The Sony RX100 is an exception here though, lacking both a hot shoe